

A FEW GOOD WOMEN

Illegal sand quarrying, bogus ration cards or inter-caste clashes, nine female civil servants in the state brave all odds to weed out corruption and bring reforms in the district of Mandya

Photographs by GIREESH GV



■ By Stephen David

A bank officer, a schoolteacher of English and a filmmaker for Doordarshan. Between them, the nine women officers of Karnataka Administrative Services (KAS) in Mandya district, average age 28, encompass all. With mentoring from the district's deputy commissioner, N. Manjunatha Prasad, these officers are not just breaking the glass ceiling but creating waves in the Cauvery heartland thanks to their dedication to work. One of the first commandments from Prasad was that they forget they were officers and be accessible to the people at all times.

Thirty-two-year-old Kavitha Rajaram was an English professor before she became a KAS officer. As Mandya taluk tehsildar, she took the lead in imposing a curfew in the area to keep tension at bay following the brutal daylight murder of notorious Congress councillor Jadeja Ravi last month. It was left to officers like Rajaram and her immediate boss

MANDYA'S MAIDENS

KAVITHA RAJARAM Tehsildar of Mandya taluk is a 32-year-old former professor of English

R. LATHA Assistant commissioner of Mandya, is a 34-year-old former bank officer

R. MEGHANA Election tehsildar, is a 24-year-old arts graduate

DHANALAKSHMI Tehsildar of Malavalli taluk, 34

KUMUDA GIRISH Assistant director of food and civil supplies, 29

R. KAVITHA RANI Tehsildar of Srirangapatna, 30

B.R. POORNIMA Assistant commissioner of Pandavapura, 34

R. SUMA Taluk tehsildar of Krishnarajapet, is a 33-year-old documentary filmmaker and a former advocate

V.R. SHYLAJA Tehsildar of Pandavapura, is a 29-year-old former lecturer of geography

DEDICATED: Prasad with his squad of female officers at the Mandya district headquarters

R. Latha, 34, district assistant commissioner and a former bank officer, to bring Mandya back to normalcy. "This job teaches you to take immediate decisions for the common good and forget about your own comfort zone," says Rajaram, who puts in 12 hours everyday in her work as do her fellow female officers. Latha and Rajaram have children but they say their families play a key role in helping them maintain the work-life balance.

Latha remembers her first day at work in July last year, "The day I reported, I landed up at Ullenhalli where there were clashes between an upper caste and Dalits. We saw Prasad handle the situation tactfully and find a solution within minutes." Prasad, an IAS officer and IIT-Delhi alumnus, served for 12 years in the toughest districts of West Bengal before coming back to his own state Karnataka. He gives credit to his young female officers for much of the good work done in